

PSAT 10

High-Yield 30

30 High-Yield Questions Weighted to the Real Digital PSAT 10 Blueprint

Reading & Writing • Math • Full Answer Explanations

Exclusive bonus for readers of the PSAT 10 Study Guide

Copyright

PSAT 10 High-Yield 30

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How This Bonus Was Built

These 30 questions are not a random sample. They are weighted to approximate the real digital PSAT 10 section proportions: the official test splits its 98 questions 54 Reading & Writing to 44 Math, so this bonus mirrors that with 17 Reading & Writing questions and 13 Math questions.

Within Reading & Writing, the question types reflect the four official domains — Craft and Structure, Information and Ideas, Standard English Conventions, and Expression of Ideas. Within Math, the four official domains are covered too — Algebra, Advanced Math, Problem-Solving and Data Analysis, and Geometry and Trigonometry.

Every question below includes a full explanation: why the correct answer is right, and why each of the other choices is wrong. That second part is what most practice sets skip — and it's usually where the actual learning happens.

Reading and Writing

Question 1 | Craft and Structure — Words in Context

Passage: Marine biologists studying deep-sea vent communities have long assumed that such ecosystems are largely self-contained, but recent tracking data reveal a surprising _____: larvae from vent-dwelling species have been found drifting hundreds of miles away, settling in entirely different vent fields.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. certainty
- B. isolation
- C. connectivity
- D. decline

Correct Answer: C

"Connectivity" matches the idea that larvae travel between distant vent fields, linking populations once assumed to be separate. "Certainty" and "decline" don't relate to the movement described. "Isolation" is the opposite of what the data show — vent communities turn out NOT to be self-contained.

Question 2 | Craft and Structure — Words in Context

Passage: Despite the committee's initial _____ about funding an untested teaching method, pilot classroom results were compelling enough that the program was expanded district-wide within a year.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical and precise word or phrase?

- A. reluctance
- B. enthusiasm
- C. indifference
- D. familiarity

Correct Answer: A

"Reluctance" fits "despite... initial [X]" being overcome by compelling results — the committee was hesitant at first. "Enthusiasm" wouldn't need to be overcome by good results. "Indifference" and "familiarity" don't create the contrast the sentence needs, since "despite" signals a shift from doubt to acceptance.

Question 3 | Craft and Structure — Text Structure and Purpose

Passage: A city planner proposed closing Elm Street to car traffic on weekends. Local shop owners worried that reduced car access would hurt sales. The planner responded by citing data from three other cities where similar closures had increased foot traffic and, within a year, raised nearby retail revenue by an average of 18%.

Which choice best describes the function of the last sentence in the passage?

- A. It undermines the planner's proposal by revealing a flaw in the data.
- B. It shifts the discussion to an unrelated aspect of city planning.

- C. It summarizes the shop owners' objection in more detail.
- D. It offers evidence intended to address the shop owners' concern.

Correct Answer: D

The last sentence gives concrete data — revenue increases in other cities — directly responding to the shop owners' worry about lost sales; that's evidence addressing their concern. It doesn't undermine the proposal (choice A; no flaw is mentioned), doesn't shift topics (choice B), and doesn't merely restate the objection (choice C) — it answers it.

Question 4 | Craft and Structure — Text Structure and Purpose

Passage: The essay opens with a vivid description of a single abandoned factory, then gradually widens its focus to the economic decline of the entire town, and finally ends by connecting that decline to national manufacturing trends.

Which choice best describes the overall structure of the essay?

- A. It repeats the same claim in three different forms for emphasis.
- B. It moves from a specific, local image to a broader national context.
- C. It presents two opposing arguments and evaluates each in turn.
- D. It moves from general national trends to a specific local example.

Correct Answer: B

The essay explicitly moves from one factory (specific/local) to the town (broader) to national trends (broadest) — specific to general. Choice D reverses that order. Choices A and C describe structures (repetition, argument/counterargument) that aren't present in the description given.

Question 5 | Information and Ideas — Central Ideas and Details

Passage: A 2024 study tracked 400 commuters who switched from driving to cycling for their daily commute. Researchers measured self-reported stress levels before and after the switch. On average, participants reported a 22% drop in stress within two months, though the effect was smaller for commuters whose routes included heavy traffic intersections.

Which choice best states the main finding of the study?

- A. Cycling commutes are always less stressful than driving commutes, regardless of route.
- B. Switching to cycling was associated with reduced stress, though busy intersections lessened the effect.
- C. Commuters who drive report significantly more stress than commuters who walk.
- D. The study found no meaningful relationship between commute method and stress.

Correct Answer: B

Choice B captures both parts of the finding: an overall stress reduction and the qualification that busy intersections lessened the effect. Choice A overstates the finding by ignoring that qualifier ("always," "regardless of route"). Choice C introduces walking, which the passage never mentions. Choice D contradicts the reported 22% drop.

Question 6 | Information and Ideas — Central Ideas and Details

Passage: Coral reefs cover less than 1% of the ocean floor, yet they support roughly a quarter of all known marine species. This concentration of biodiversity makes reefs a priority for conservation, even though their small physical footprint might suggest otherwise.

According to the passage, why are coral reefs considered a conservation priority?

- A. Because they cover a very large portion of the ocean floor.
- B. Because they are the only ocean habitat that supports marine life.
- C. Because they support a disproportionately large share of marine species relative to their size.
- D. Because their small size makes them easy to protect.

Correct Answer: C

The passage's central contrast is between small area (under 1%) and large species share (a quarter) — that disproportion is why reefs matter. Choice A is factually wrong; the passage says reefs cover very little area. Choice B overstates the claim with "only." Choice D isn't stated or implied anywhere in the passage.

Question 7 | Information and Ideas — Command of Evidence

Passage: A researcher claims that home tutoring in mathematics improves standardized test scores more than group tutoring does. Two groups of 50 students each received 10 weeks of tutoring; the home-tutoring group's average score rose from 68 to 79, while the group-tutoring group's average rose from 67 to 74.

Which choice best supports the researcher's claim?

- A. The home-tutoring group's average gain (11 points) was larger than the group-tutoring group's average gain (7 points).
- B. Both groups started with nearly identical average scores.
- C. Each group contained exactly 50 students.
- D. The tutoring lasted 10 weeks for both groups.

Correct Answer: A

The claim is a comparison of effectiveness, so the relevant evidence is the size of each group's improvement: home tutoring gained more points (11 vs. 7). Choices B, C, and D describe conditions that were equal between the two groups — useful for a fair comparison, but they don't by themselves show that one method worked better.

Question 8 | Information and Ideas — Command of Evidence

Passage: A city council member argues that a new bike-lane network reduced traffic congestion downtown. Average commute times downtown were 34 minutes before the bike lanes were installed and 31 minutes one year after installation. During the same year, the city also synchronized several downtown traffic lights.

Which choice best describes a weakness in using the commute-time data to support the council member's claim?

- A. The commute times were not measured in the same city.
- B. The sample size of commuters was too small to be meaningful.
- C. Commute times actually increased after the bike lanes were installed.

- D. A second change (traffic-light synchronization) occurred during the same period, so the drop in commute times can't be attributed to the bike lanes alone.

Correct Answer: D

Because the traffic-light synchronization happened at the same time as the bike-lane installation, the 3-minute drop could be caused by either change, or both — the data alone can't isolate the bike lanes' effect. Choices A and C are factually wrong according to the passage (commute times were measured downtown, and they decreased, not increased). Choice B isn't addressed by the passage at all.

Question 9 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The museum's new wing features a recreated dig site _____ visitors can search for artifacts themselves.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. were
- B. we're
- C. where
- D. where,

Correct Answer: C

"Where" correctly introduces a clause describing the dig site (a place). "Were" (choice A) and "we're" (choice B) are homophones that don't fit grammatically — the sentence needs a relative pronoun referring to a location, not a verb or contraction. Choice D adds an unnecessary comma that incorrectly separates the clause from the site it describes.

Question 10 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The collection of rare manuscripts, donated by three separate alumni over the past decade, _____ housed in a climate-controlled room on the library's top floor.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. are
- B. is
- C. were
- D. have been

Correct Answer: B

The subject of the sentence is "the collection" (singular), not "manuscripts" or "alumni," which sit inside a modifying phrase. A singular subject takes "is." Choices A, C, and D all agree with a plural noun instead of the true singular subject.

Question 11 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: By the time the results were announced, the two _____ methods had already been adopted by several other labs studying the same phenomenon.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. researcher's
- B. researchers's
- C. researchers
- D. researchers'

Correct Answer: D

"Researchers'" is the correct plural possessive — since there are two researchers, the apostrophe goes after the "s." Choice A is singular possessive, but the sentence describes two researchers. Choice B ("researchers's") isn't a standard English form. Choice C has no apostrophe at all, leaving "methods" without an owner.

Question 12 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: Originally designed for military communication, engineers eventually adapted the technology for civilian use in hospitals and schools.

Which choice best revises the sentence to correct a misplaced modifier?

- A. Originally designed for military communication, the technology was eventually adapted by engineers for civilian use in hospitals and schools.
- B. Originally designed for military communication, civilian use in hospitals and schools eventually came from engineers adapting the technology.
- C. Engineers, originally designed for military communication, eventually adapted the technology for civilian use in hospitals and schools.
- D. No change is needed.

Correct Answer: A

The opening phrase "Originally designed for military communication" describes the technology, not the engineers, so "the technology" must immediately follow the comma — which only choice A does. The original sentence (and choice C) incorrectly implies the engineers were "originally designed for military communication." Choice B still doesn't place "the technology" right after the modifier.

Question 13 | Standard English Conventions

Passage: The novel's final chapter, which many critics consider the strongest part of the book _____ resolves every major plot thread introduced in the first half.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

- A. ;
- B. ,
- C. .
- D. (no punctuation)

Correct Answer: B

The clause "which many critics consider the strongest part of the book" is nonessential information inserted into the main sentence ("The novel's final chapter... resolves every major plot thread") — nonessential clauses need a comma

on both sides. Since the clause already opens with a comma, it must close with one too (choice B). Ending it with a semicolon, period, or no punctuation instead breaks the sentence's grammar.

Question 14 | Expression of Ideas — Transitions

Passage: The new library wing was completed six months ahead of schedule. _____, the project came in nearly 12% under its original budget.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. However
- B. For example
- C. Additionally
- D. In contrast

Correct Answer: C

Both sentences describe positive outcomes of the same project — early completion and under-budget spending — so "Additionally" (choice C) correctly signals that a second positive fact is being added. "However" (A) and "In contrast" (D) wrongly signal a contradiction where none exists. "For example" (B) wrongly implies the budget fact is an instance of the schedule fact, when they're two separate facts.

Question 15 | Expression of Ideas — Transitions

Passage: Many species of migratory birds rely on magnetic fields to navigate. Increasing electromagnetic interference from urban areas, _____, may be disrupting these natural navigation systems.

Which choice completes the text with the most logical transition?

- A. researchers suspect
- B. for instance
- C. in other words
- D. therefore

Correct Answer: A

"Researchers suspect" (choice A) works as a parenthetical attribution — the sentence reads naturally as "interference..., researchers suspect, may be disrupting....," signaling this is a hypothesis rather than a proven fact. "For instance" (B) and "in other words" (C) don't fit that parenthetical slot. "Therefore" (D) would need to signal a logical conclusion, but nothing earlier in the text establishes a cause requiring "therefore."

Question 16 | Expression of Ideas — Rhetorical Synthesis

Passage: A student has researched two facts:

- A local nonprofit distributed 4,000 winter coats to families in need last year.
- The nonprofit relies entirely on volunteer labor and donated materials, with no paid staff.

The student wants to emphasize how the nonprofit achieved a large impact with minimal resources.

Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. The nonprofit distributed winter coats last year, and it relies on volunteers.

- B. The nonprofit distributed 4,000 coats last year, and it has no paid staff.
- C. Last year was a successful year for the nonprofit, which gave away thousands of coats.
- D. Despite relying entirely on volunteer labor and donated materials, the nonprofit distributed 4,000 coats to families in need last year.

Correct Answer: D

Choice D directly connects the minimal resources (all-volunteer, no paid staff) to the large impact (4,000 coats) with "despite," which is exactly the emphasis the student wants. Choice B lists both facts but without framing them as impact-despite-limited-resources. Choice A omits the specific coat count. Choice C is vague ("thousands") and drops the volunteer-only detail entirely.

Question 17 | Expression of Ideas — Rhetorical Synthesis

Passage: A student has researched two facts:

- A community garden project converted 12 vacant lots into growing spaces over three years.
- A survey found that residents near the converted lots reported a 30% increase in sense of neighborhood safety.

The student wants to present the connection between the garden project and residents' sense of safety.

Which choice most effectively uses relevant information from the notes to accomplish this goal?

- A. Community gardens are a popular way to make use of vacant lots in cities.
- B. After the community garden project converted 12 vacant lots into growing spaces, nearby residents reported a 30% increase in their sense of neighborhood safety.
- C. The community garden project converted 12 vacant lots into growing spaces over three years.
- D. A survey found that residents reported a 30% increase in their sense of neighborhood safety.

Correct Answer: B

Choice B links both facts together — the conversion project, then the resulting survey finding — in a single connected statement, exactly the connection the student wants to present. Choices C and D each state only one fact alone. Choice A is a general claim not drawn from the specific notes at all.

Math

Question 18 | Algebra

If $5x - 3 = 2x + 15$, what is the value of x ?

- A. 6
- B. 4
- C. 8
- D. 12

Correct Answer: A

$5x - 3 = 2x + 15 \rightarrow 5x - 2x = 15 + 3 \rightarrow 3x = 18 \rightarrow x = 6$. Choice B would result from combining the constants incorrectly; choices C and D don't satisfy the original equation when substituted back in.

Question 19 | Algebra

The system of equations $2x + y = 11$ and $x - y = 1$ has solution (x, y) . What is the value of $x + y$?

- A. 5
- B. 9
- C. 11
- D. 7

Correct Answer: D

Adding the two equations directly eliminates y : $(2x + y) + (x - y) = 11 + 1$, so $3x = 12$ and $x = 4$. From $x - y = 1$, $y = 3$. So $x + y = 4 + 3 = 7$. Choice A would come from an arithmetic slip solving for y ; choices B and C don't satisfy both original equations.

Question 20 | Algebra

A parking garage charges \$4 for the first hour and \$2.50 for each additional hour. If Maya has at most \$16.50 to spend, what is the maximum number of whole hours she can park?

- A. 4
- B. 5
- C. 6
- D. 7

Correct Answer: C

The cost for h hours ($h \geq 1$) is $4 + 2.5(h - 1)$. Setting $4 + 2.5(h - 1) \leq 16.50$ gives $2.5(h - 1) \leq 12.5$, so $h - 1 \leq 5$ and $h \leq 6$. At $h = 6$ the cost is exactly \$16.50, within budget; at $h = 7$ (choice D) the cost would be \$19.00, over budget. Choices A and B don't use the full amount available.

Question 21 | Advanced Math

What are the solutions to $x^2 - 5x - 14 = 0$?

- A. $x = 2$ and $x = 7$
- B. $x = -2$ and $x = 7$
- C. $x = -7$ and $x = 2$
- D. $x = -2$ and $x = -7$

Correct Answer: B

$x^2 - 5x - 14$ factors as $(x - 7)(x + 2)$, since $-7 \times 2 = -14$ and $-7 + 2 = -5$. Setting each factor to zero gives $x = 7$ and $x = -2$. The other choices come from sign errors made while factoring.

Question 22 | Advanced Math

For $x > 0$, $(x^{4/3})^2 = x^k$. What is the value of k ?

- A. $8/3$
- B. $2/3$
- C. 6
- D. $16/9$

Correct Answer: A

Raising a power to a power multiplies the exponents: $(4/3) \times 2 = 8/3$. Choice B results from dividing instead of multiplying the exponents; choices C and D come from other common exponent-rule errors.

Question 23 | Advanced Math

The function $f(x) = 2(x - 3)^2 + 1$. What is $f(5)$?

- A. 5
- B. 7
- C. 11
- D. 9

Correct Answer: D

Substituting $x = 5$: $2(5 - 3)^2 + 1 = 2(2)^2 + 1 = 2(4) + 1 = 9$. Choice B would result from squaring before subtracting inside the parentheses incorrectly; choices A and C come from other order-of-operations slips.

Question 24 | Advanced Math

For $P(x) = 3x^2 - 5x + 4$, what is the remainder when $P(x)$ is divided by $(x - 2)$?

- A. 2
- B. 4
- C. 6
- D. 10

Correct Answer: C

By the Remainder Theorem, the remainder when $P(x)$ is divided by $(x - 2)$ equals $P(2)$: $3(2)^2 - 5(2) + 4 = 12 - 10 + 4 = 6$. The other choices come from arithmetic slips evaluating $P(2)$.

Question 25 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

A backpack's price was reduced from \$80 to \$68. By what percent was the price reduced?

- A. 12%
- B. 15%
- C. 17%
- D. 20%

Correct Answer: B

The dollar decrease is $\$80 - \$68 = \$12$. As a percent of the original price: $12/80 = 0.15 = 15\%$. Choice A mistakes the dollar amount for the percent; choices C and D come from dividing by the wrong base.

Question 26 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

In a random sample of 180 students, 120 reported owning a bicycle. Based on this sample, how many students out of a school of 900 would be expected to own a bicycle?

- A. 600
- B. 450
- C. 720
- D. 540

Correct Answer: A

The sample proportion is $120/180 = 2/3$. Applying that proportion to 900 students: $900 \times 2/3 = 600$. Choice D would come from using $3/5$ instead of $2/3$; choices B and C come from other proportion errors.

Question 27 | Problem-Solving and Data Analysis

Five students scored 72, 85, 90, 68, and 80 on a quiz. What is the median score?

- A. 78
- B. 79
- C. 81
- D. 80

Correct Answer: D

Sorting the scores gives 68, 72, 80, 85, 90. With five values, the median is the middle (third) value: 80. Choices A, B, and C are close to the mean (79) or other miscalculations, not the median.

Question 28 | Geometry and Trigonometry

A right triangle has legs of length 9 and 12. What is its area?

- A. 27
- B. 108
- C. 54

D. 21

Correct Answer: C

The area of a right triangle is half the product of its two legs: $(1/2)(9)(12) = 54$. Choice B omits the factor of $1/2$; choices A and D come from other arithmetic errors.

Question 29 | Geometry and Trigonometry

A circle has a diameter of 14. What is its area, in terms of π ?

A. 14π

B. 49π

C. 196π

D. 28π

Correct Answer: B

The radius is half the diameter: $14/2 = 7$. Area = $\pi r^2 = \pi(7)^2 = 49\pi$. Choice A confuses diameter with area; choice C squares the diameter instead of the radius.

Question 30 | Geometry and Trigonometry

In right triangle ABC, angle C is the right angle, the length of side BC (opposite angle A) is 6, and the length of the hypotenuse AB is 10. What is $\sin(A)$?

A. $3/5$

B. $4/5$

C. $5/3$

D. $5/4$

Correct Answer: A

$\sin(A)$ is the ratio of the side opposite angle A to the hypotenuse: $6/10 = 3/5$. Choice B ($4/5$) would be $\cos(A)$, using the other leg (8, found via the Pythagorean theorem) over the hypotenuse. Choices C and D invert the correct ratios.